

Learning Intention: I can read and understand information about soils, rocks and minerals, and explain why they are important resources.

Success Criteria — I can:

- Identify observable properties of soils, rocks and minerals.
- Explain why soils, rocks and minerals are important Earth resources.
- Answer literal and inferred questions about a nonfiction text.

Reading Strategy

Before reading, look at the heading and any bold words — they tell you what the text is about. As you read, look for **facts** (what something is) and **reasons** (why it matters).

Read — Earth's Natural Materials

Under our feet, the Earth is made up of different natural materials: **soil**, **rock**, and **minerals**. Each one has its own properties, and each one is important in a different way.

Soil is a loose mixture of broken-down rock, decayed plants and animals, water and air. Soil can be sandy, rocky, or full of dark, crumbly material called humus. Farmers rely on healthy soil to grow the crops that feed us, because soil holds water and nutrients that plant roots need.

Rock is hard and solid, and it doesn't crumble apart the way soil does. Rocks can be rough or smooth, dull or shiny, and come in many colours. Builders use rock — like granite and sandstone — to construct roads, buildings and bridges because it is strong and long-lasting.

A **mineral** is a natural solid substance with a specific structure, often found inside rock. Quartz, salt and gold are all minerals. Some minerals are valuable because they are rare or useful — salt is used in food, and metals like iron and copper are taken from mineral-rich rock to make tools, wires and coins.

Soils, rocks and minerals are called **Earth resources** because people use them every day — for food, for building, and for making the objects around us.

Vocabulary Helper

Word	Meaning
Property	A quality you can observe, like colour, hardness or texture
Resource	A natural material that people use
Humus	Dark, crumbly material in soil made from decayed plants

Parent Tip

Next time you're in the garden or at a park, dig up a small handful of soil together and look closely — can you spot any tiny rock pieces? Talk about what you can see, feel and smell.

Did You Know?

It can take hundreds of years for nature to form just a few centimetres of soil, as rock slowly breaks down and mixes with decayed plants and animals. That's why looking after soil is so important — it can't be quickly replaced once it's gone!

Find It, Think About It & Apply

Q1 — Find It (Literal)

- a) What is soil made from? _____
- b) Name two rocks mentioned in the text. _____
- c) Name three minerals mentioned in the text. _____

Q2 — Think About It (Inferred)

- a) Why do farmers need healthy soil? _____
- b) Why do builders choose rock instead of soil for buildings? _____

Q3 — Sort the Properties

Write whether each description matches soil, rock, or a mineral.

Description	Soil / Rock / Mineral
Loose and crumbly, holds water for plant roots	
Hard and solid, used to build roads and bridges	
A natural solid substance, sometimes rare or valuable	

Q4 — Match the Resource to Its Use

Resource	Use (write the letter)
Soil	
Rock	
Metal (from mineral-rich rock)	

A = Building roads and bridges B = Making wires, tools and coins C = Growing crops for food

Watch Out!

Rocks and minerals are not the same thing — a mineral is often found inside a rock. A rock can actually be made of several different minerals combined together.

Q5 — True or False?

Statement	True / False
A rock and a mineral are always exactly the same thing.	True / False
Soil contains water and air as well as broken-down rock.	True / False

Apply & Reasoning — Use what you've read to explain your thinking.

- 1 Reasoning:** Compare a rock and soil. Give one way they are different and explain why this difference matters for how each is used.

- 2 Reasoning:** In your own words, explain why minerals are considered a valuable Earth resource.

- 3 Open-ended:** Choose a rock, soil type, or mineral you know about (or invent one). Describe its observable properties and explain one way people could use it as a resource.

Quick Check — Exit Ticket

Name one property that helps you tell rock apart from soil.

Answer & Teacher Support

Answer Key — Pages 1 & 2

Q1 (p2): a) Broken-down rock, decayed plants/animals, water and air. b) Granite and sandstone. c) Quartz, salt and gold.

Q2 (p2): a) Soil holds the water and nutrients that plant roots need to grow crops. b) Rock is strong and long-lasting, unlike soil which is loose and crumbly.

Q3 (p2): Loose/crumbly, holds water — Soil. Hard/solid, used for building — Rock. Natural solid substance, rare/valuable — Mineral.

Q4 (p2): Soil — C. Rock — A. Metal — B.

Q5 (p2): "Rock and mineral always the same" — False. "Soil contains water and air" — True.

Answer Key — Page 3

Q1 (acceptable-answer guide): Accept any valid difference (e.g. rock is hard/solid, soil is loose/crumbly) linked to a sensible reason for its use (e.g. rock's strength suits building; soil's looseness suits plant growth).

Q2: Minerals are valuable because they can be rare, and because people use them to make useful things like tools, wires, coins and food (salt).

Q3 (acceptable-answer guide): Accept any response describing plausible observable properties (colour, texture, hardness) and a genuine real-world or reasonable imagined use.

Exit ticket: Accept any valid property, e.g. rock is hard/solid while soil is loose/crumbly.

Teacher Checklist

- ☐ Retrieves literal facts from the nonfiction text.
- ☐ Makes reasonable inferences beyond the text.
- ☐ Sorts soil, rock and mineral by observable properties.
- ☐ Matches each resource to a real-world use.
- ☐ Evaluates true/false statements about rock and soil properties.
- ☐ Explains why Earth resources are important, in own words.

Teacher Tip

This resource combines nonfiction reading comprehension with AC9S3U02 (soils, rocks and minerals as Earth resources) — a genuine curriculum gap this fills. Pair with a real soil/rock observation activity if hands-on materials are available.